

Expedition Report: Hopefully No Mutiny

Pling initiated an expedition to the Great Maw to evaluate safety concerns for the Striders Guild, as the guild was considering building a potential outpost in the region to strengthen political ties with King Toot. He was accompanied by Gaven, Oxyotl, and Sedressel. We assembled on the first day at the northern gate of Haven, preparing for a three-day journey north to reach the Dreglords. A few hours into our trek, we encountered a copper knight statue pointing east. It clearly required some form of magic to activate, but we opted to leave it undisturbed and press on. By the end of the day, we discovered a cave occupied by partying darkstriders who invited us to join them. Pling indulged and became somewhat drunk, but the night passed without further incident, and we were able to sleep there safely.

On the second day, we stumbled upon ruins containing fifteen flesh balloons. Prioritizing the expedition, we wisely decided to detour around them. Later that night, a bizarre purple eclipse materialized in the sky, and a humanoid figure emerged from it. This phenomenon was accompanied by an earth tremor originating from the north. Lacking intelligence on the strange creature, we decided to set out at dawn, heading directly toward the source of the tremor.

On the third day, we arrived at the Great Maw, where a goblin festival was in full swing. Pling made a gesture of goodwill by donating flutes and knives to the local goblins. Gaven employed his telepathy to speak into the guards' minds, successfully convincing them he was the Great Maw itself; this resulted in one of the guards jumping into the Maw. The remaining guards then decided to let us meet with the king. Pling presented King Toot with a painting he had received from Lao, which the king absolutely loved. Eventually, we managed to convince the king to let us approach the Great Maw, though there were strict conditions: Oxyotl and Sedressel were forced to wear blindfolds and earplugs. We made it clear that Gaven was already blind and thus only needed earplugs, while Pling was permitted to freely descend. We were informed that priests would be following and guiding us.

Even near the entrance, we observed large cracks forming in the depths, making it look as though the area would crumble soon. At the bottom, the party perceived the Great Maw. It appeared to be a sand-worm-like entity with a massive fleshy mouth, and it was creating tremors. We were able to confirm that this creature was the very source of the tremors we felt during the previous night.

While King Toot delivered his speech, we seized the opportunity to sneak away and infiltrate the forbidden mines. Inside, we found traces of potential past Striders who had been here before us, though we believe they never made it back. Deeper still, we uncovered an open chasm revealing the ruins of an old, unknown civilization that matched nothing previously reported by Striders. We proceeded toward a tower, noticing that flying crystals patrolled the area and coated all the buildings, perfectly matching the crystals found near the Great Maw. We decided to enter the tower, but a clumsy misstep alerted two spectators, which we managed to fend off.

Inside, we discovered a book detailing a tuning fork and the defenses of the city of Marzelth; moreover, the text indicated that these tools were the key to creating protective magical barriers around the city. We also found Elvish symbols and deduced that this might be a

displaced city from the Astral Sea, though how it arrived here or whether it had been attacked remains a mystery. At the tower's peak, we engaged animated armors and found a huge tuning fork. Due to the rampant wild magic in the area, we accidentally created an anti-magic field during our skirmish. After defeating the armors, we noticed the tuning fork was deactivated—leaving us to wonder if our anti-magic field caused it and what the consequences might be.

We decided to head back down and found a gate that led further into the depths toward the Great Maw. Eventually, we uncovered the creature's crystallized heart. It was visibly beating, and we witnessed it spreading the corrupting crystals throughout the area; even the civilians tossed into the Great Maw were being corrupted into crystal beings. Gaven identified the massive beast as an Astral Dreadnought. Realizing the catastrophic problems it would cause if ignored, we chose to fight it. The heart summoned a formidable crystal golem, leading to a brutal battle, but we successfully shattered the heart just before the cavern began to collapse on us. We managed to slip back out through the festival's commotion to gather our strength and deliver this report. Moving forward, Pling faces a delicate diplomatic task to ensure we keep the Dreglords as allies.

- Report made by Oxyotl